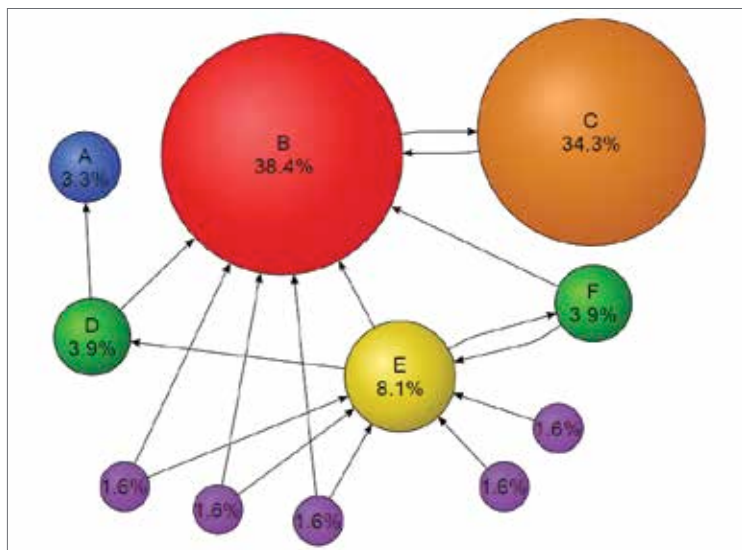


Out of some obscure sense of political (technological?) correctness and a slightly comical spirit of inclusiveness, we tend to use the broad term “search engine” when we in fact have in mind Google - the search and advertising behemoth that has broadened its horizons (and, dare we say, invaded ours rather aggressively) in the past decade and a half. This chapter will talk about Google’s PageRank algorithm that ranks its search results, the updates to it, and how they have improved the quality of results that it churns out.

Google’s PageRank translates simple and intuitive principles into rigorous and efficient math to give you high quality, relevant results. A high ranking page implies more relevant content and less annoying spam. If a high ranking page links to another webpage, it’s a fair assumption that the linked page is important and reliable as well. PageRank does consider it so, and is therefore recursive in that sense. The second factor that determines the rank of a page is its actual content -- its text, how it’s formatted, how it looks, and what the pages it links to contain.

Judging a book by its cover



A very rudimentary visual representation of Google’s PageRank algorithm. A lot of pages link to B, so it’s important. B links only to C. Even though C has just one link to it, it’s from an important website. That makes C important as well.